



MW practical exam

An aide-mémoire developed by the education team to assist MW candidates preparing for the practical exam
Please note that this document should be read in conjunction with the MW practical exam guidelines.

KEY STRUCTURAL ELEMENTS

Colour
Acidity
Alcohol
Tannin
Oak
Residual sugar
Texture
Fruit
Concentration/intensity
Length
Balance

MW PRACTICAL QUESTIONS GRAPE VARIETY

Use the most obvious of these indicators but especially:

Acidity
Alcohol
Tannin
Residual sugar
Fruit/aromas
Colour
Winemaking

ORIGIN

Cool, moderate or hot climate?
New World or Old World?
Pronounced or subtle aromas?
Fruit
Alcohol
Acidity
Types of tannins (ripe v tight)
Any other obvious indicators (e.g. RS for Germany)
Quality
Be specific on classic areas

QUALITY

Concentration: weight and depth of fruit
Complexity: oak, MLF, lees, earthy, mineral, autolysis
Length
Balance
Ageability
"Context of origin" e.g. 1er Cru, Reserva, Cru Classe, Single Vineyard, Puttonyos

MATURITY

Colour
Balance
Primary/tertiary aromas
Sugar/acid/tannin balance and structure
Reductive/oxidative
Integration
How old is the wine now (in years)? Will the wine improve? If so, how will it develop? How long will it keep?

STYLE

Carte Blanche to be creative with these types of questions. Some ideas: Dry-sweet
Light/full bodied
Easy drinking/complex Unoaked/oaked Overt/subtle
Immediate drinking/Long term ageing
Think of terms that may be on the label: Spatlese, Oloroso, Blanc de Blancs, Brut, Recioto...

METHOD OF PRODUCTION

Grape variety(ies)
Ripeness and origin e.g. high yielding v low yielding sites
Fermentation vessel and time
Fermentation temperatures
Maceration and Tannin management
MLF
Lees contact
Blending e.g. reserve wines
Oak: barrel/chips, new v old, origin (French/American), time
Always relate to what you can taste in the glass

COMMERCIAL POTENTIAL/APPEAL

Retail price in £,\$,€
Type of consumer (broad range or niche)
Trade sector: on v off trade
Style: mass market brand or artisanal boutique
Appeal: Chardonnay or Cabernet drinker, light bodied or full-bodied styles...
Domestic v export
Be creative

COMPARE AND CONTRAST QUESTIONS

Refer equally to the number of wines involved
Use words like: "In contrast", "in comparison", "however", "whereas" to highlight the differences

FINAL TIPS

Read questions carefully
Underline key words
Look at allocation of marks
Don't spend too long on first question
Use key words of question in your answer e.g. style, quality
Multiple part questions - refer to all parts in your answer
Draw up list of adjectives to describe grape varieties, countries and regions
Have a plan on timing and stick to it
Decide tasting order
Don't overtaste
First impressions count most
Write neatly
Be honest with yourself!
Enjoy it, don't be afraid of it.